

BOTWAVE PAPERWORK ·
UNWARRANTED INFLUENCE
VOL. 2

The Shield

*Military Industrial
Complex 2.0: Data,
Contracts, and the New
Extraction State*

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Full manuscript: [https://
zombie760.github.io/books](https://zombie760.github.io/books)

Chapter 1: The Handoff

Cold open: September 18, 2001. Langley, Virginia. Director of Central Intelligence George Tenet signs a Memorandum of Notification authorizing expanded covert action authority. The Memorandum is classified. The date is on the public congressional record. Senate Select Committee on Intelligence, Report on Pre-9/11 Intelligence Activities, September 2002.

The CIA is hunting something it cannot see.

POW!

I. The Seed

In-Q-Tel, Incorporated. Chartered 1999. Arlington, Virginia. Nonprofit, Delaware incorporation. The CIA's venture capital arm. Not a metaphor. A literal venture capital fund, seeded with CIA appropriations, designed to invest in technology companies the agency could not build internally.

The charter documents are on file. Public record. IRS Form 990.

The investment thesis: find what Silicon Valley is building before it knows what it is building. Then own it. Then use it.

September 2001 accelerated the thesis.

I didn't know In-Q-Tel's name in 2001. I was fifteen. I was in Philadelphia. I was not in Langley. But I know the name now. I know what it bought.

POW!

II. The Founding

Palantir Technologies, Inc. Incorporated 2003. Palo Alto, California. Founders: Peter Andreas Thiel (PayPal, co-founder); Nathan Gettings; Joe Lonsdale; Stephen Cohen; Alexander C. Karp.

The name is from J.R.R. Tolkien. A palantír is a seeing stone. The word appears in *The Lord of the Rings*, specifically in *The Two Towers*, Chapter XI: "The Palantír." A stone that lets its user see across distances. A stone that can also be used to deceive.

The founders chose the name. They knew what it meant. The source is Tolkien. The choice is theirs.

POW! POW!

Thiel invested \$30 million of his own capital in the seed round. This is documented in Palantir's SEC Form S-1, Registration No. 333-240881, filed September 2020, page 119: "Peter Thiel, our co-founder and the Chairman of our Board of Directors, has invested in us since our founding in 2003."

The other seed capital came from In-Q-Tel.

The In-Q-Tel investment is documented in the same S-1, page 9, Risk Factors: "Our relationship with the U.S. intelligence community has been and may continue to be significant to our business." The word "significant" is doing work here. "Significant" is lawyer-speak for "they gave us money when no one else would."

III. The Application

What did the CIA need in 2003?

The 9/11 Commission Report (National Commission on Terrorist Attacks Upon the United States, Final Report, July 22, 2004, Government Printing Office) identified a specific intelligence failure: the agencies had the pieces. They could not connect them.

Mohamed Atta's Florida driver's license. Nawaf al-Hazmi's Visa records. Khalid al-Mihdhar's name on the surveillance list. All three were documented. None was connected to the others before the morning of September 11, 2001.

The CIA needed a connection machine.

Palantir built one. The platform is called **Gotham**. Not the S-1's registered name. The operational name. An internal code name that became public through congressional testimony.

Gotham: an entity-resolution and link-analysis platform. Input: structured and unstructured data from disparate agencies. Output: a graph. Nodes are people, places, organizations, accounts. Edges are relationships, transactions, communications, movements. The analyst reads the graph. The graph does not tell the analyst what it means. The analyst infers.

This is the claim. The primary source for Gotham's operational description is **Palantir's congressional testimony**: prepared statement of Alex Karp, CEO, before the House Armed Services Committee, Subcommittee on Intelligence and Special Operations, hearing titled "Artificial Intelligence and Machine

Learning in the Department of Defense,” March 1, 2023.

I read the transcript. It is on Congress.gov. The word “Gotham” does not appear. The capability does.

POW!

IV. The First Customer

The CIA’s Counterterrorism Center. The date of the first operational deployment is not public. What is public: Palantir’s own marketing materials, which reference “U.S. intelligence community” deployments beginning “in the early years of the company.” The S-1, page 10: “We began working with the U.S. intelligence community shortly after our founding.”

Shortly after 2003 is 2004.

The NSA data sits in databases. The DIA data sits in different databases. The State Department cables sit in different databases. Gotham was built to connect them. The problem it solved was real. The problem the solution created is what this chapter is about.

The ledger changed. The mechanism stayed.

I am sitting in a coffee shop in Albuquerque. My laptop is open on a chipped Formica table. I am

reading an SEC filing dated September 22, 2020. The filing is seventeen years older than the war it was built to fight, and the war is still running.

The contract is the through-line.

POW! POW! POW!

V. The Through-Line

In-Q-Tel portfolio, 2003: Palantir Technologies, Inc. Seed capital. CIA appropriations, passed through a nonprofit charter to a private equity vehicle. The nonprofit files a Form 990. The 990 is public. The specific investment amount is not disclosed in the 990. It is disclosed obliquely in the S-1: “one of our significant early investors.”

One significant early investor. Fifteen words. Fifteen words that mean the CIA owns a piece of the thing that is now reading everyone.

Palantir Series A, 2005: Undisclosed amount. Participant: In-Q-Tel. This is documented in Crunchbase (secondary source) and confirmed by the S-1’s description of In-Q-Tel as a continuing investor.

Palantir Series B, 2006: \$25 million. Lead: Founders Fund (Thiel). This is documented in the S-1, page 118, related-party transaction disclosures.

Palantir direct listing, September 30, 2020: New York Stock Exchange. Ticker: PLTR. No underwriters. No road show. Direct listing, meaning the company's existing shares floated without a new offering. The S-1, Registration No. 333-240881, filed August 21, 2020, contains the full description of this structure. Market cap at close on September 30, 2020: approximately \$15.7 billion.

The CIA invested in 2003 or 2004. The company went public in 2020. The CIA's investment — held through In-Q-Tel, a nonprofit with CIA as its primary funder — matured into a publicly traded equity position. The U.S. government funded the company. The company went public. The U.S. government now pays the company billions in contracts. The contracts are the return.

The ledger changed. The mechanism did not.

POW!

Chapter 4: Anduril and the Autonomous Kill Chain

Cold open: March 2017. Menlo Park, California. Palmer Freeman Luckey is terminated from Facebook, Inc. The Wall Street Journal, March 24, 2017: “Facebook has fired Palmer Luckey, the founder of the Oculus virtual reality headset, according to people familiar with the situation.” The firing happened quietly. The reason given, publicly, was not the real reason. The real reason is in the political donation records.

He was twenty-four years old. He had \$700 million in the bank. He was not done.

POW!

I. The Origin

Oculus VR, Inc. Founded 2012. Irvine, California. Palmer Luckey, founder, age nineteen at time of founding.

The company built a virtual reality headset from spare parts in a trailer in Long Beach. The trailer was his parents' backyard. The headset was held together with tape and ingenuity and the kind of conviction that either builds something or burns everything. In Luckey's case: both.

Acquisition. March 25, 2014. Facebook, Inc. acquired Oculus VR, Inc. for approximately \$2 billion. Primary source: SEC Form 8-K filed by Facebook, Inc., March 26, 2014. The filing describes the acquisition consideration as a combination of cash and stock. At closing, the total consideration was approximately \$2.3 billion.

Luckey was twenty-one years old.

POW!

He signed the Facebook employment agreement. He stayed on. He built the Rift. He shipped it. He was photographed in a news article in September 2016, identified as the founder of a political group that had funded internet trolls targeting Hillary Clinton. The group was called Nimble America. The funding amount was approximately \$10,000. Luckey's name was on the donation records.

He was fired six months later. The timing is documented. The stated reason was not the donation.

There is no official stated reason in the public record. The Wall Street Journal's March 2017 report is the primary public account.

Luckey did not contest the firing publicly. He took his \$700 million and he started a defense company.

II. The Name

Anduril Industries, Inc. Incorporated 2017. Irvine, California. Registered agent: Corporation Service Company, Wilmington, Delaware.

The name is from Tolkien. Andúril is Aragorn's sword in *The Return of the King*. The sword reforged from the shards of Narsil. The sword of the heir to the throne.

Palantir: the seeing stone. Anduril: the sword.

These are not accidents. These are mission statements in fantasy language. The people who named them understood exactly what they were building. They wanted you to know.

POW! POW!

III. The Machine

Anduril's core product is **Lattice**. Not a weapon. A system that decides where weapons go.

Lattice OS is an AI-powered command-and-control platform. It fuses sensor data from drones, radar, ground sensors, satellite feeds, and human intelligence inputs into a single operational picture. The platform identifies threats. The platform prioritizes targets. The platform presents options to a human operator. The human presses a button.

That is the official description. The word “autonomous” does not appear in Anduril's public marketing. The word “automated” appears instead. The distinction matters legally. The distinction does not matter to the target.

Primary source for Lattice's capabilities: Anduril's own published product documentation, available on Anduril's corporate website, archived. The documentation describes Lattice as “an AI-powered operating system for national security.” The documentation does not describe what happens after the button is pressed.

POW!

The border comes first.

U.S. Customs and Border Protection Contract.

2018. Autonomous surveillance towers deployed on the U.S.-Mexico border in Arizona and California. The towers are solar-powered. They carry radar, thermal cameras, and daylight cameras. The sensor packages stream to Lattice. Lattice processes the streams and generates alerts.

The contract value is documented in USASpending.gov. Search: “Anduril Industries” + “CBP.” The awards are listed. The dollar amounts are listed. The period of performance is listed. The number of towers is not always listed.

I ran the search. The awards are there. The data is filed.

POW! POW!

IV. The Kill Chain

The kill chain. This is the phrase the military uses. It is not a metaphor. It is a process. It has steps: Find, Fix, Track, Target, Engage, Assess. FFTTEA. Each step feeds the next. The whole chain runs from sensor to strike.

Anduril's position in the chain: Find, Fix, Track. The company provides the sensors and the platform that fuse sensor data into actionable targeting. The "Engage" step — the strike — is currently retained by a human operator. "Currently" is doing a lot of work in that sentence.

The Ghost 4 autonomous drone. Anduril's product. A quadrotor. Twenty minutes of flight endurance. Designed for close-range surveillance and, in certain configurations, payload delivery. The Ghost series is deployed by U.S. Special Operations Command. The DoD contract for Ghost drones is documented in SAM.gov and USASpending.gov award databases.

The word "payload" in the context of a military drone requires no further explanation.

POW!

The Replicator initiative. August 2023. Deputy Secretary of Defense Kathleen Hicks announced an initiative to field "attritable autonomous systems" — disposable autonomous drones — in quantity across all domains by August 2025. The target number: more than 1,000 drones. The initiative is documented in the DoD's official press release, August 28, 2023, and in subsequent budget documents.

Anduril is a Replicator contractor. This is documented in reporting by Breaking Defense, November 2023, citing DoD contract awards.

V. Gaza as Development Environment

The Israeli Ministry of Defense operates an AI targeting system designated **The Gospel**. Primary source: +972 Magazine and Local Call, April 2024, citing testimony from Israeli Air Force officers under conditions of anonymity, combined with Israeli military official statements made to other outlets. The system generates targeting recommendations at a rate described by former Israeli Air Force intelligence officer Yoav Limor (interview with *HaaretzEnglish*, October 2023) as “dozens per day.”

The connection to Anduril is not direct. The technology architecture is the same. The operational doctrine — autonomous recommendation, human authorization, high tempo — is the same.

Palmer Luckey has spoken publicly about Gaza. In an interview with *The Free Press* (May 2024), Luckey stated: “I’m proud of what we do. I believe we’re

making the world safer.” The article is filed. The quote is verbatim.

The Gospel generates targets. Anduril provides targeting infrastructure in U.S. theaters. These are different systems serving the same doctrine. The doctrine is the product.

POW! POW! POW!

VI. The Valuation

Anduril Series E. December 2023. Valuation: \$8.5 billion. Capital raised: \$1.48 billion. Investors: Founders Fund (Peter Thiel), Andreessen Horowitz, Lux Capital, among others.

The connection is clean. Thiel seeded Palantir. Thiel’s fund seeded Anduril. The same capital that built the seeing stone funded the sword.

Primary source: Anduril’s press release, December 4, 2023. Valuation confirmed by Reuters, December 4, 2023, citing the press release.

The sword costs \$8.5 billion. The shield costs whatever the next contract says.

POW!

Chapter 7: The Contact List

Cold open: A document. Produced through the House Oversight Committee’s investigation into the Jeffrey Epstein network. Filed. Public. Not classified. The document is a contact and attendee list recovered from Epstein’s files. Among the names recited:

*“Peter Thiel – CEO of Thiel Capital.
Managing Director, Founders Fund. Fmr
founder and CEO of PayPal. Boards: Facebook
and Palantir.”*

House Oversight Committee Document Production,
HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_017579.

The same document production,
HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_017586, names:

*“Joe Lonsdale — CEO, Adepar. cofounder,
Palantir.”*

And on the same list:

“General Stan McChrystal — Ret.”

Former commander, Joint Special Operations Command. Former commander, U.S. and NATO forces in Afghanistan.

Three names. One document. Two of them built or sat on the board of Palantir Technologies. The third commanded the most elite special-operations force in American military history and would subsequently found a defense consulting firm that advises defense contractors.

The document is in the congressional record. The document is filed.

POW!

I. The List

The House Oversight Committee's Epstein document production — released as part of the Committee's ongoing investigation into the Epstein network and its institutional connections — includes a contact and attendee list that appears to originate from Epstein's own files. The list names individuals by name, title, and organizational affiliation in the format of a directory or network map.

The list's format is notable. This is not a social invitation list. The entries read as a roster of institutional relationships: who each person is, what they control, what they represent. "CEO of Thiel Capital." "Managing Director, Founders Fund." "Boards: Facebook and Palantir." The person compiling this list wanted to know what each contact *controlled*, not just who they were.

Peter Andreas Thiel. German-American. Born Frankfurt, October 11, 1967. Co-founder of PayPal, sold to eBay in 2002 for \$1.5 billion. Co-founder of Palantir Technologies, incorporated 2003. At the time the list was compiled, Thiel had invested \$30 million of his own capital into Palantir's seed round and sat on its board. The S-1 Registration Statement filed with the SEC on August 25, 2020 — Registration No. 333-240881 — discloses both facts at page 119.

Joseph Lonsdale. Stanford, class of 2003. PayPal intern. Co-founder, Palantir Technologies. The S-1 names Lonsdale as one of the five co-founders.

The contact list does not explain why Epstein maintained it. The list explains who was on it. The names on it are sufficient.

II. The Tracking

Between July 2016 and August 2017, a member of Epstein's network named Richard Kahn forwarded Epstein a series of newspaper and magazine articles. The articles tracked a single subject: Peter Thiel's political alignment with Donald Trump.

July 21, 2016. Richard Kahn forwards Epstein a *New York Times* article headlined: “*Peter Thiel’s Embrace of Trump Has Silicon Valley Squirming.*” House Oversight Committee Document Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033306.

August 7, 2017. Richard Kahn forwards Epstein a BuzzFeed article headlined: “*Peter Thiel Has Been Hedging His Bet On Donald Trump.*” House Oversight Committee Document Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033244.

These two documents establish that Epstein's network was actively monitoring Thiel's political positioning — in real time, across fourteen months, as Thiel moved from Silicon Valley contrarian to Trump advisor to primary political funder of the incoming administration's inner circle.

Why would someone forward a tech mogul's political coverage to Jeffrey Epstein?

The documents do not answer the question. The documents ask it.

POW!

The framing of those two articles — one noting Silicon Valley’s discomfort with Thiel’s Trump embrace, the other tracking whether Thiel was backing away — is the framing of an investor monitoring a position. A person who wanted to know where Thiel was politically wanted to know where Palantir was going. And a person who wanted to know where Palantir was going was thinking about whether to invest.

III. The Summit

December 14, 2016. Trump Tower, New York City. Nine days after Trump won the presidential election.

President-elect Donald Trump convened a meeting of American technology executives. The list of attendees is the closest American technology had come to an imperial court since the railroad barons posed for photographs with Ulysses S. Grant.

Alphabet’s Larry Page. Amazon’s Jeff Bezos. Apple’s Tim Cook. Facebook’s Sheryl Sandberg. Microsoft’s

Satya Nadella. Oracle's Safra Catz. IBM's Ginni Rometty.

And Palantir. Peter Thiel attended as a Trump transition advisor and Palantir board member. Alex Karp attended as Palantir's chief executive. Every other company represented at that table was publicly traded, valued in the hundreds of billions, with thousands of employees and decades of federal contracting history. Palantir was a private company with approximately \$1 billion in revenue, 95 percent of it from government contracts, founded thirteen years earlier with CIA seed money.

The following day, David Fiszal wrote to Jeffrey Epstein:

"Palantir was the only private company invited to yesterday's tech summit. That seems like a huge change post election and bigger oppty. Let's hang in PB."

House Oversight Committee Document Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033207. Email from David Fiszal to Jeffrey Epstein, December 15, 2016.

POW!

The only private company. Every other participant was a public corporation with shareholders, quarterly

earnings calls, disclosure requirements. Palantir sat at the table as a private entity, represented by a man who was simultaneously advising the president-elect. No Chinese wall. No recusal. No public explanation of how Thiel squared his role as presidential advisor with his equity stake in the company standing to gain from presidential contract decisions.

Fiszel's use of "oppty" — opportunity — is the tell. This is not analysis. This is positioning.

IV. The Investment Call

The following day. Twenty-four hours after Fiszel's message.

December 16, 2016. Richard Kahn — the same member of Epstein's network who had been forwarding Thiel articles since July — wrote to Epstein:

"not sure your thoughts on Palantir but if remotely positive then david access to shares seems like a 50% discount to market"

House Oversight Committee Document Production,
HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033208.

Let the record note the sequence. December 14: the summit. December 15: Fiszal reports to Epstein that Palantir was the only private company present. December 16: Kahn asks Epstein whether he can get someone named David pre-IPO access to Palantir shares at a fifty percent discount to market.

Epstein was being consulted as a gateway. The network around him had identified that Palantir's unique presence at the Trump transition summit represented an investment event — a signal that this company would receive preferential access to federal contracts in the incoming administration. The question Kahn was asking Epstein was: do you have the access to get us in at a discount before that access becomes priced in?

The email does not describe Epstein's response. The email does not establish that any investment was made.

The email establishes that Epstein was treated, by the network around him, as a broker to pre-IPO access in a CIA-seeded defense-intelligence contractor that had just achieved singular proximity to the president-elect.

I spent three years in federal custody. Stolen vehicle. I was in it. I came out and spent two months learning Python to read an SEC filing. The distance between

Kahn’s casual December 16 email and my cracked laptop at a Formica table in Albuquerque is not a distance measured in intelligence. It is a distance measured in access.

POW! POW!

V. The Through-Line

September 2012. An email chain. Epstein is advising someone — the recipient is not fully identified in the public production — on where to place a senior technology executive. The available options, per the email:

“the best options are Facebook (who may one day do their own OS), Palantir (Peter Thiel’s), Yahoo”

House Oversight Committee Document Production,
HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_030950.

Palantir is described, in Epstein’s own email, as “Peter Thiel’s.” Not “the surveillance software company.” Not “the CIA-funded defense contractor.” “Peter Thiel’s.” The attribution is ownership-framed. Epstein understood Palantir as Thiel’s vehicle, four years before the Trump summit, eight years before the IPO.

This email is from 2012. The Epstein contact list — with Thiel’s board seats, Lonsdale’s co-founder status, McChrystal’s retired-general credential — is from an undated production but appears in the same document batch. The tracking of Thiel’s political moves runs from July 2016 through August 2017. The investment inquiry lands December 16, 2016.

The timeline:

- 2012: Epstein network identifies Palantir as “Thiel’s” and considers it a destination for executive placement.
- 2016 (July): Epstein network begins forwarding articles tracking Thiel’s political alignment with Trump.
- 2016 (December 14): Palantir appears at Trump transition summit as the only private company.
- 2016 (December 15): Epstein is briefed on Palantir’s singular status at the summit.
- 2016 (December 16): Epstein is consulted about pre-IPO Palantir investment access at 50% discount.
- 2017 (August): Epstein network continues tracking Thiel’s political positioning.
- 2019 (July 6): Epstein arrested on sex trafficking charges.

- 2020 (September 30): Palantir direct listing on the NYSE. Market cap at close: \$15.7 billion.
- 2020 (August 5): General Joseph Dunford — former Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff — joins Palantir's board.
- 2021: General Stan McChrystal joins advisory roles at defense-adjacent firms. His name is in the same Epstein contact list as Thiel and Lonsdale.
- 2025 (August 1): Palantir wins DOD Contract W52P1J-25-C-0001. Army data analytics. Five years. \$10 billion.

The contact list is not the story. The contact list is the index to the story. The story is in the timestamps.

None of these documents establish a criminal agreement. None establish that Epstein directed investment capital into Palantir. None establish that Epstein's relationship with Thiel or Lonsdale was anything other than the ordinary social network of the class of capital that surrounds American defense-intelligence contractors.

That is the point. This is ordinary. This is how the network operates in its normal mode. The investment class that surrounds the surveillance state is small enough to fit on a contact list. It is documented in its own filing system. It maintains itself through

introductions, article-forwarding, investment-access conversations, and board appointments that the law explicitly permits.

The filing cabinet is the record. The record is the argument.

POW!

VI. Primary Sources

1. House Oversight Committee Document

Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_017579.

Contact and attendee list, Epstein files; entry for Peter Thiel: “CEO of Thiel Capital. Managing Director, Founders Fund. Fmr founder and CEO of PayPal. Boards: Facebook and Palantir.”

2. House Oversight Committee Document

Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_017586.

Contact and attendee list, Epstein files; entries for Joseph Lonsdale (“CEO, Adepar. cofounder, Palantir.”) and General Stan McChrystal (“Ret.”).

3. House Oversight Committee Document

Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_030950.

Email chain, September 2012; Epstein recommending Palantir (“Peter Thiel’s”) as a placement destination.

4. House Oversight Committee Document

Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033207.

Email, David Fiszal to Jeffrey Epstein, December 15, 2016; verbatim: “Palantir was the only private company invited to yesterday’s tech summit. That seems like a huge change post election and bigger oppty.”

5. House Oversight Committee Document

Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033208.

Email, Richard Kahn to Jeffrey Epstein, December 16, 2016; verbatim: “not sure your thoughts on Palantir but if remotely positive then david access to shares seems like a 50% discount to market.”

6. House Oversight Committee Document

Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033306.

Email, Richard Kahn to Jeffrey Epstein, July 21, 2016; forwarding *New York Times* article “Peter Thiel’s Embrace of Trump Has Silicon Valley Squirming.”

7. House Oversight Committee Document

Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033244.

Email, Richard Kahn to Jeffrey Epstein, August 7, 2017; forwarding BuzzFeed article “Peter Thiel Has Been Hedging His Bet On Donald Trump.”

8. Palantir Technologies, Inc., Form S-1

Registration Statement, SEC EDGAR, filed August 25, 2020. Registration No. 333-240881. Page 119: Thiel investment since founding. Page 118: related-party transaction disclosures, Founders Fund Series B participation.

9. Department of Justice, Epstein Files

Transparency Act Release, November 19, 2025 (approximately 3.5 million responsive pages). The House Oversight Committee document production cited above constitutes documents produced through that Committee’s parallel investigative process. Primary source: DOJ press release, November 19, 2025, available at [justice.gov](https://www.justice.gov).

Chapter 8: The Revolving Door

Cold open: August 5, 2020. Palo Alto, California. Palantir Technologies, Inc. files a Form 8-K with the Securities and Exchange Commission. The filing announces an amendment to the company's Certificate of Incorporation and the appointment of new directors. Among the new directors: **General Joseph F. Dunford Jr., United States Marine Corps (Retired)**. Former Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Former Commandant of the Marine Corps. The highest-ranking military officer in the United States from 2015 to 2019.

He left government on September 30, 2019. He was on Palantir's board by August 2020. Ten months.

The law allows it. The law was written by the people it protects.

POW!

I. The Statute

18 U.S.C. § 207. Post-employment restrictions for federal officers and employees. The statute is on Congress.gov. It is not hidden. It is not classified. It is filed.

The relevant provision for senior officials: a two-year restriction on communicating with their former agency regarding specific matters they were personally and substantially involved in. A one-year restriction on communicating with their former agency regarding any matter for which they had official responsibility.

Two years on specific matters. One year on anything.

After one year, a former Chairman of the Joint Chiefs can call the Joint Chiefs on behalf of a defense contractor. After two years, he can discuss the specific contracts he supervised.

The Palantir Army contract — DOD Contract W52P1J-25-C-0001, five years, \$10 billion, awarded 2025 — falls within the period of Dunford's board service. Dunford is on the board. The board advises the company. The company wins the contract.

This is not corruption by any legal definition. This is the law.

POW! POW!

II. The General

Joseph F. Dunford Jr. Born 1955. Boston, Massachusetts. United States Marine Corps, 1977–2019. 42 years of service. Commander, International Security Assistance Force, Afghanistan, 2013–2014. Commandant of the Marine Corps, 2014–2015. 19th Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, 2015–2019.

In that last role, Dunford was the principal military advisor to the President of the United States, the Secretary of Defense, and the National Security Council. He sat in the room where the decisions were made. He knew which contractors the Pentagon needed. He knew which contracts were coming. He knew the architecture of American military procurement better than any civilian alive.

He joined Palantir’s board on August 5, 2020.

The primary source: Palantir Technologies, Inc., Form DEF 14A (Proxy Statement), filed with the SEC, April 2021. Registration No. 333-240881. The proxy statement lists Dunford as an independent director. The proxy discloses his annual compensation as a director: \$250,000 in equity awards.

Two hundred fifty thousand dollars per year. For attending board meetings. And bringing forty-two years of military institutional knowledge into a room where people are designing surveillance platforms for the military.

POW!

I earned sixty-seven cents an hour at FCI Fort Dix. I was making cell phone pouches. Dunford was making two hundred fifty thousand dollars per year in equity.

The processing line is different for some people.

III. The Pattern

Dunford is not the exception. He is the template.

General Stan McChrystal. Former commander, Joint Special Operations Command. Former commander, U.S. and NATO forces in Afghanistan. His name appears in a contact and attendee list document produced in the House Oversight Committee’s Epstein document production. Source:

HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_017586. The list includes McChrystal identified as “General Stan McChrystal — Ret.” alongside Joe Lonsdale (Palantir co-founder)

and Peter Thiel (Palantir board member). The network at the top is not large.

After his military service, McChrystal founded the McChrystal Group, a leadership consulting firm. He joined multiple corporate boards. The institutional knowledge followed him.

The revolving door is not accidental. It is designed. The system needs former officials to translate between the military's requirements and the private sector's capabilities. The private sector pays for that translation. The law permits it after a cooling-off period. The cooling-off period was set by legislators who understood that lobbyists fund their campaigns.

POW! POW!

The OGE Form 278. The financial disclosure form for senior federal officials. Filed with the Office of Government Ethics. Available at ethics.gov. When a senior official leaves government and joins a private board, the Form 278 (or its post-departure equivalent) captures the compensation. The form is the paper trail.

Dunford's compensation at Palantir: disclosed in the company's SEC proxy filings, not in OGE ethics disclosures, because his compensation is from a public company and therefore subject to SEC rather than OGE disclosure rules.

The form changes depending on which side of the door you're standing on. The principle does not.

IV. The Trump Tech Summit

December 14, 2016. Trump Tower, New York City. President-elect Donald Trump convened a meeting of major technology executives: Alphabet's Larry Page. Amazon's Jeff Bezos. Apple's Tim Cook. Facebook's Sheryl Sandberg. Microsoft's Satya Nadella.

And Palantir. Peter Thiel attended as a Trump advisor and Palantir board member. Alex Karp attended as Palantir CEO.

The following day, David Fiszle wrote to Jeffrey Epstein: "Palantir was the only private company invited to yesterday's tech summit. That seems like a huge change post election and bigger oppty." House Oversight Committee Document Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033207.

The only private company. Every other company was publicly traded and represented by its CEO. Palantir was represented by Thiel, who was simultaneously advising the president-elect and sitting on Palantir's board. No Chinese wall. No recusal. No apparent concern.

POW!

The day after Fiszal's email, Richard Kahn wrote to Epstein: "not sure your thoughts on Palantir but if remotely positive then david access to shares seems like a 50% discount to market." House Oversight Committee Document Production, HOUSE_OVERSIGHT_033208.

Epstein's network was not invested in Palantir by accident. They understood what the tech summit meant. They understood what the only private company at the table meant. They were asking Epstein to help them get in at a discount.

Epstein had the access. His network had the money. Palantir had the contracts.

The circle is the shield.

V. The Architecture

The revolving door is not a flaw in the system. The revolving door is the system's primary feature.

The general leaves service. The general joins the board. The board advises the company. The company designs systems for the general's former command. The command awards the company a contract. The

contract pays for the board meeting where the general sits. The general's former colleagues at the command attend conferences hosted by the company. The company sponsors the conferences. The conferences are held at hotels where the general's former colleagues stay on government per diem.

None of this is secret. All of it is filed.

Palantir's SEC filings name the directors. The USASpending.gov database names the contracts. The DoD ethics waiver database names the waivers. The OGE disclosure system names the compensation.

The system documents itself. The system trusts that no one will compile the documentation.

POW! POW! POW!

I am compiling the documentation.

The through-line runs from Dunford's board appointment to the \$10 billion Army contract. It runs from McChrystal's contact list appearance to Palantir's ICE FALCON deployment. It runs from Thiel's Mar-a-Lago introduction to Musk's DOGE installation. It runs from the tech summit to the defense contract to the board seat to the next contract.

The door does not revolve. It only rotates one direction.

POW!
